

Mandarin duck

Aix galericulata

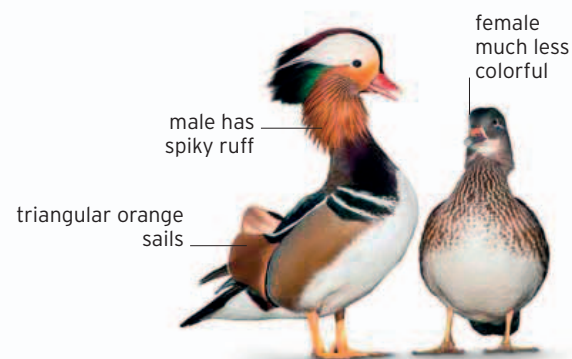
Like many brightly patterned birds, mandarin ducks are surprisingly inconspicuous in the wild. They usually keep well out of sight beneath overhanging lakeside vegetation, or perch high up in trees. In spring, they nest in cavities in old trees. Males defend occupied nests at first, but do not incubate the eggs and leave the area before they hatch. Mandarins feed on small invertebrates, seeds, acorns, and other vegetable matter, taken from shallow water or while grazing on nearby short grass. They fly quickly through trees and across open water, making high-pitched, squeaky, quacking calls.

Numbers game

Habitat loss and exploitation have caused a dramatic decline in the mandarin's natural range, but, being an ornamental bird, it has been introduced into parts of Europe. Some mandarins escaped from collections to establish wild populations in North America. Normally, such out-of-range introductions turn out to be ecologically damaging, but in the mandarin's case, they may prove to be the species' salvation in the long term.

- ↔ 16–20 in (41–50 cm)
- 🏠 22 oz (625 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🍷 Seeds, nuts, insects, snails
- 🏠 

E. Asia



broad white crescent of male



◁ MAGNIFICENT MALE

Few birds look quite so singular. While the male is unique, the female looks like a female American wood duck.

Mandarin ducks **symbolize lifelong fidelity and affection** in Chinese culture